

The 13 types of *YouTube* Thumbnails

[For thumbnail help, click here](#)

Here's a statistical fact:

91% of all YouTube videos use the same 13 thumbnails

In this doc, we're breaking them down, showing what makes them so clickable, and why they're everywhere on YouTube. First, let's talk about ducks.
(btw- all of the thumbnails are linked to the videos).

1. Duck out of Water



I took my duck to Gucci

3.3M views • 2 years ago

seDUCKtive

This is a duck in front of a Gucci shop. Usually you don't find ducks at a Gucci shop. You find ducks in a body of water — this duck is not in water. This is the first of 13 thumbnails: *the duck out of water*. The reason this thumbnail was the gateway to getting 3.3 million views is because as soon as people saw it, they had a list of questions form in their head and they had to know the answer to them, such as...

- Why is there a duck in front of a Gucci shop?
- What are the Sales people going to do when this duck goes into that Gucci shop?
- Will the duck wear Gucci, and if so, what Gucci clothes will the duck choose?
- What will the other Gucci customers say about this duck Gucci customer?
- Is this guy crazy enough that he's actually going to buy Gucci for his duck?

That's why this video got a lot of views — because when someone, even a duck, gets taken out of their natural habitat and put in a new situation they shouldn't be in, people have to see it. But don't trust me, let me prove it with another *duck out of water* thumbnail.



I Entered Mr Universe - With No Training

2.4M views • 1 year ago



Max Fosh

This guy has no tan and no shoulder caps. That is not something you find at a bodybuilding competition. So that means he's the duck, which makes this competition the "out of water." How are these dudes going to react when he shows up? Maybe it will be about the crazy world of bodybuilding or how tiny he is compared to them and what it took for those bodybuilders to get to where they are today. That sounds like some wholesome entertainment. Or maybe it will just be a metaphor for the humiliation that life can be sometimes. Glad it was him, not me.



Goofy sings Evanescence's Bring Me to Life

12M views • 10 years ago



ProZD

Okay it looks like Goofy with... I'm not sure? Maybe a death metal band? Goofy never struck me as a death metal guy. But I guess they are going to have a weird sing-a-long.



I Faked My Grandpa To The Top of Fashion Week

9.7M views • 1 year ago



Zac Alsop

Here they tell us this old man is *the duck out of water* because he's a fake model... that means he's not a *real* model, which means he shouldn't be there, which means he's the duck. How will this grandpa pull it off?

The Duck out of Water thumbnail is all about throwing the main character into a completely strange and uncomfortable situation. People see it and they can predict all of the good stuff that's gonna happen.

2. Puzzle to be Solved



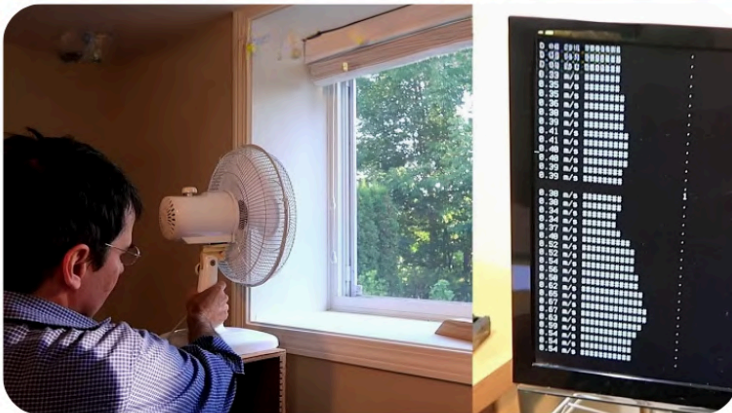
Why 80% of Americans Live East of This Line

9.6M views · 2 years ago



Okay that's America. I know maps, I know my geography. They are saying — 20% live here and 80% live there. But it looks like almost an even 50/50 split of America's land mass. Weird. When someone just points out facts that you can't explain, that you got to know why it is that way? They've created a puzzle to be solved, and the only way to solve it is by clicking.

So let's look at this thumbnail:



He has a fan pointed at a window... pretty boring thumbnail, I would never click.

But as soon as he puts up the text...

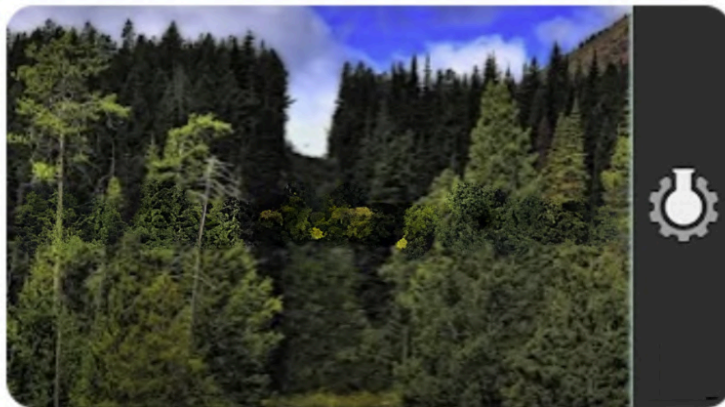


Best fan placement to move air through the house

8.2M views • 3 years ago

Matthias random stuff

“further away is better?”- I'm like, *yeah where?! Where is the best place to put a fan? I've only seen fans in the window.* Maybe you never even thought about where to put your fan in the window to cool down your house. Maybe you weren't even aware that you would be interested in this until someone poses it as a question, and then you go, *where is better?* And now me and 8 million other people just needed to know. He took a common household thing and turned it into a puzzle to solve.



Okay trees- boring.
Strip of grass- boring.

But look what happens when you add in text:



Canada & The United States's Bizarre Border

29M views • 11 years ago



No touching zone — wait a second they're not allowed to touch? They got covid or something? Or is that like a religious thing? Without the text it looks like a trail...*with* the text it's a puzzle to solve.



Why New York's Billionaires' Row Is Half Empty

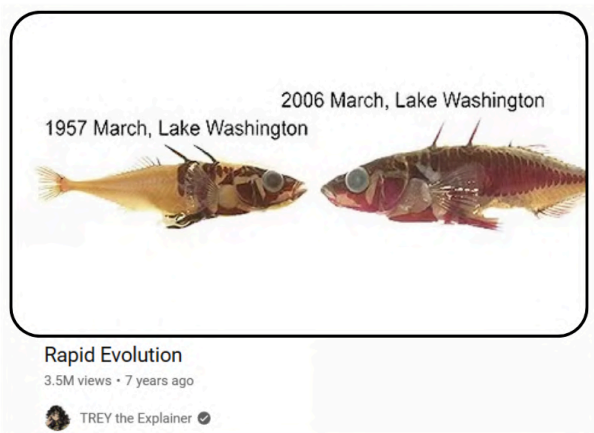
19M views • 3 years ago



Here this thumbnail says, "New York City's tallest buildings are half empty." Now that is a statement, not a question—except for now, in your mind, it's like, "Well, why *is* it half empty?" Which they followed up with in the title: "Why New York Billionaires' Row Is Half Empty." Gotta click—guess that's why it got 19 million views.

On a deeper biological level, humans love puzzles because it's practice for how to solve problems.

If you can solve a puzzle, you can solve a problem. And what is life? It's a bunch of problems to solve. That's why puzzle to solve is one of the most popular YouTube thumbnail formats.



Why did this fish change so much in 50 years?
It's a puzzle to solve.



Why do gifted kids take a nose dive? Puzzle to solve.



How does this house rotate? Puzzle to solve.

3. Apples to Oranges



Okay looks like a totally normal pickup truck...kinda



Worlds Smallest Truck vs Worlds Largest Truck

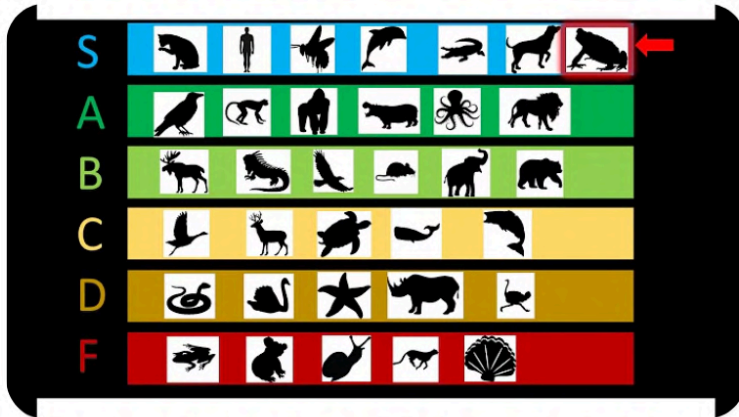
19M views • 1 year ago



Holy smokes, that's not a normal truck, it's the world's smallest truck.

**You only know how small something is by
comparing it to something big—**

Which is why the Apples to Oranges thumbnail exists. You might say, don't you mean apples to apples? No, that's some boring school shit—**why would you want to compare the same thing to the same thing?** This is YouTube...boring doesn't work. So WhistlinDiesel here is going to tell us how the smallest truck in the world compares to the largest truck in the world—that'll be educational.



Are all amphibians low tier? [SECRET TOP TIER]

2M views • 7 years ago



Why do some animals just seem better than other animals? This guy is going to compare and contrast all the animals on a tier list. Cool. I wonder who is going to win? It should be elephants. Here are a couple other apples to oranges:



What Are the Theoretical Limits of Human Strength?

3.1M views • 1 year ago



A strong man compared to another strong man is kinda boring. But a strong man compared to a *gorilla*? Way more views.



New Prius vs 30-Year-Old Bentley

2.1M views • 1 year ago



How does a 2024 Prius compare to a 1995 Rolls Bentley? Apples to oranges.



\$649 Dyson Fan vs. \$15 Walmart Fan: The Hard Truth



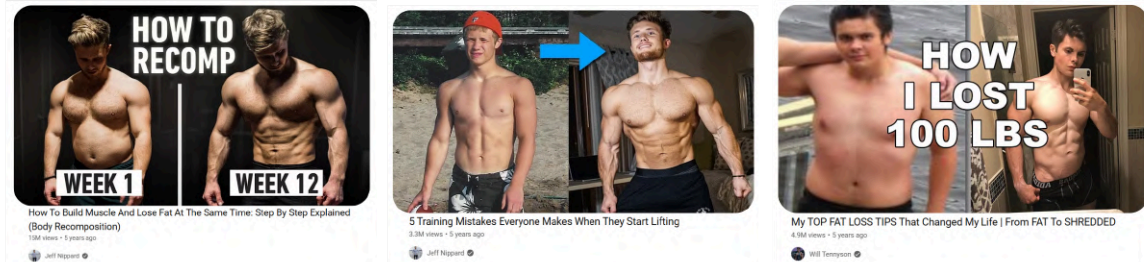
I have a couple of friends who would say you can't compare a \$700 Dyson fan to a \$15 Walmart fan. And that's why they are my friends and not YouTubers.

Apples to oranges compare completely different things, and the next thumbnail format does too.

4. The Level Up Thumbnail

They show you the start, they show you the end, and if the difference is big enough, you gotta know how they did it.

The fitness world loves a good level up for obvious reasons



There are three level-ups here.

1. "I am huge; but I have to show everyone by getting shredded."
2. "I went from skinny kid to huge."
3. "I went from chubby kid to Adonis."

The "before" shows me this person understands who I am and where I'm coming from.

The "after" proves that they did it, and now they probably know something about it. And what do I think? I think...*if it's possible for them, it just might be possible for me.* And then I click.

Another type of level up is the classic rags to riches story:



From a young Scottish boy to a raging entrepreneur with a heart of gold—I'd click on that story. But not all level-ups have to be an epic transformation story from skinny to huge or poor to rich. The level up is such an effective thumbnail that it even works for the most basic of skills—cooking eggs.



They got the egg sticking and they got the yolk breaking, which is two big problems I've definitely had, and that's a mistake I would like to fix. I'm clicking on that.

The DIY world is also a big fan of the level up:

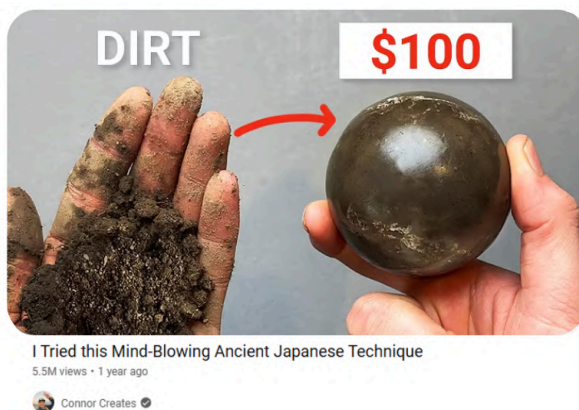


Most transformations make you ask, how'd they do that? In this case, it's also why'd they do that, and why does this skinny woman have these huge pants? And how'd she get it done in one minute? And where did the other leg go? That's the real magic of 5 Minute Crafts.

The core human experience is all about getting better—from not being able to crawl, to crawling, to walking, to running... you get my metaphor; going from A to B. How we change and improve, and the step-by-step process by which we do it, is why "level up" is one of the greatest thumbnail formats of all time.

Here are a couple of other level ups.

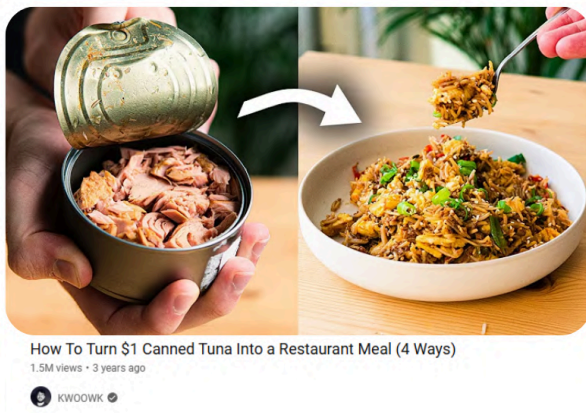
Turning dirt into a smooth shiny thing:



This is a triple level up: Weight loss, wealth, and wardrobe



Taking an ordinary can of tuna and turning it into a servable meal:



5. War of 2 Worlds

*Trigger warning: I'm going to say *war is good*.

War: what is it good for? Actually, quite a lot. You might say, "But you just said humans teaching humans is one of the greatest things you've ever seen."

It is! But you teach them so they can go to war with somebody else if they have to. Take Mr. Beast—he loves war.

Kids vs. adults:



100 Kids Vs 100 Adults For \$500,000

297M views • 2 years ago



Boys vs girls:



100 Boys Vs 100 Girls For \$500,000

247M views • 2 years ago



Those were pretty straight forward but here's a more complicated one:



Bike Lanes by Casey Neistat
30M views • 13 years ago

CaseyNeistat

It looks like someone was riding in a bike lane and that person has now crashed into a police car...*in* that bike lane. There is going to be trouble. And this immediately brings the question:

- how is the cyclist going to handle that police officer?
- Is the cyclist going to be in trouble for hitting the police officer's car?
- Is the police officer going to be in trouble for parking in a bike lane?

I just had to write 87 words that do a poor representation of what this photo and your brain figures out immediately. That's why this is a War of Two Worlds masterpiece with a respectable 30,362,211 views. Is it the clearest image? No. But high res doesn't always make it better... *South Park* is just a couple of circles and rectangles and they seem to have made it. And who was that YouTuber? That was a young Casey Neistat with about 1,500 subscribers, so basically 13,000,000 short of where he is today.

This is the modern version of Casey's bike lanes—I broke silly laws in front of the police:

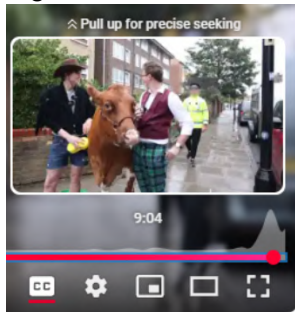


I Broke Silly Laws In Front Of The Police
7.1M views • 1 year ago

Max Fosh

Now how do you know this is a war and people are looking for the conflict?

Right there- the watch curve:



It's one of the highest points of the curve—when the police officer shows up. And Max here saves it for the very last second of the video. That's a YouTuber who knows how to use suspense. Never give the audience what they want until you're ready to close up that video.



Trying to Become Friends with a Karen!
4M views · 1 year ago

Danny Duncan

So there's this kind of stoner bro kind of guy, and he's all chill, and everything is good man, everything is good, we're having a great time—we just wanna be friends. She's not having a great time. That's conflict. And then he makes sure that there's some subliminal messages in there so you know there is going to be a war of two worlds.



Ice Boat vs. World's Hottest Lake
10M views · 4 years ago

Ryan Trahan

This is a different kind of war of two worlds: Ryan Trahan is taking on his own challenge- *his* war, riding across on a block of ice against the hot water, and he's going to do everything he can to get across—this is **man versus nature**. Will he make it to wherever he's going before his boat becomes the lake? Who knows? *I* want to know.

(Now he doesn't even believe in himself either, because he's wearing a life jacket- there has to be a chance of losing to be a game worth winning...and that's what the life jacket says).

Here's a fourth type of War of Two Worlds: a man intentionally holding himself down at the bottom of a pool with a weight.



Spending 24 Hours Straight Under Water Challenge

144M views • 6 years ago



Why is he doing this? Because he's trying to spend 24 hours underwater. You know how in the first Mr. Beast thumbnails there was gonna be some WWE stuff going to happen—kids vs adults, girls vs boys? Well, this conflict has *no WWE*. It has **all inner spirit conflict**: do you stay underwater for 15 minutes, or do you give up? This war is with himself—a man testing his own free will. No one is forcing Mr. Beast to be underwater with a 20-pound weight attached to his torso. He chose to do this because he wants to see if he can do it, and he wants *us* to see if he can do it.

When two forces collide, and A goes against B, that's a good story

And the story takes 2 paths:

1. Sometimes conflict finds the YouTuber, like with Casey and the bike lanes, and we love to watch other humans go WWE to see how they handle it.
2. Other times the YouTuber seeks out the conflict...because we love to watch other humans trying to be better humans and see how they handle it.

That is what makes the War of Two Worlds, *great*. So war was good—see? I proved it. I rest my case.

6. Talkback

Okay, so you don't want to get punched in the face. What's a way to wage war without actually going out in public? Talkbacks.

Progress in humanity has moved from using their fists to using their words, and that's why Talkbacks exist.

This is how a talkback works: this YouTuber was like “*Japan’s internet is weirdly designed*”



why Japan's internet is weirdly designed

5M views • 2 years ago

Answer in Progress

Then this YouTuber came along and was like, “You missed a bunch of stuff about why Japan’s internet is weirdly designed.”



How culture made Japanese Internet design "Weird"

1M views • 2 years ago

cynzy

You might not care...but over a million people did.

So that was a talkback to another YouTuber. You can also do a talkback to a whole subject—like this YouTuber here:



The toxic trait of interior design.

791K views • 2 years ago

Caroline Winkler

This woman went up to interior design and said *you got a problem*

Then there's talkbacks to ideas:



Why Alexander Volkanovski's Body Type Is Overpowered

286K views • 1 year ago

TJlovesFights

Most people think being bigger and taller is better for fighting. This YouTuber is saying, nah...“being short is the way to go.”

One of the most common forms of Talkbacks is a Reacts:



Everyone's favorite grandpa, Snoop, is here listening to some guy who mixed his song *Gin and Juice* with *The Jungle Book* song, and now Snoop is going to react to it. He will give his opinion on what he thinks of this musical mashup. And a little bit of foreshadowing—Snoop looks kind of like, “Who the heck has been messin with my music...” aka he’s *talking back* to this guy’s remix.

You have heard of debate class, right? Maybe you haven't...maybe you went to a school like I went to and there's no debate class. But there *is* a thing called debate class. It's where two people get up and they say their opinion about some topic. This is the origin of the Talkback video:

you say this...I say that.

Talkbacks at their best take us from our small insular lives and bring us out into the total possibility of the universe—from our caveman minds to our best selves.

7. Text

Okay, as soon as you grow up, a lot of your problems are not in the physical world anymore. That means they're not easily represented as a pictogram or a Mr. Beast thumbnail. No offense, Mr. Beast. Sometimes life gives you a situation, like how would you represent getting rejected from an Ivy League school?



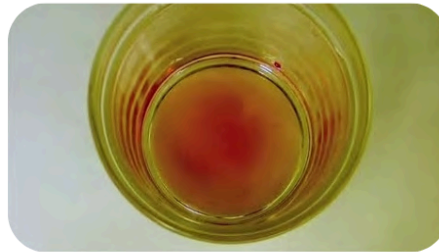
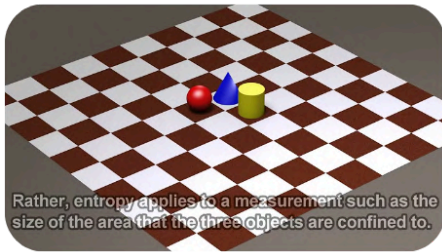
What are you going to have? A picture of a letter and you with a sad face? Doesn't make a great thumbnail.

So this YouTuber went with the most tried-and-tested mechanism that humans have for communication: **writing**. When I'm helping people with their thumbnails, I usually say, don't use words; use pictures. But people who go to MIT can read and read *well*. And when they're scrolling through YouTube they don't see a lot of text on screen and they get intrigued- it's like catnip to a cat. You know how cats go crazy for catnip? MIT Big Brains go crazy for text on a thumbnail- just gotta click.

So—how would you know when to resort to using text?

Take someone like Veritasium. Say he had a video he wanted to make about the extremely complex idea of **entropy**. I could see Veritasium sitting around the office being like, okay guys, how do we show entropy in the thumbnail? And then they just sit there and it's cricket sounds.

They try looking at what other people used for entropy thumbnails, and all they find is some weird cartoon and an empty glass:



And then finally some dude at the back of the room goes actually I have an idea...what if we just wrote the word entropy on top of a bunch of abstract looking objects?

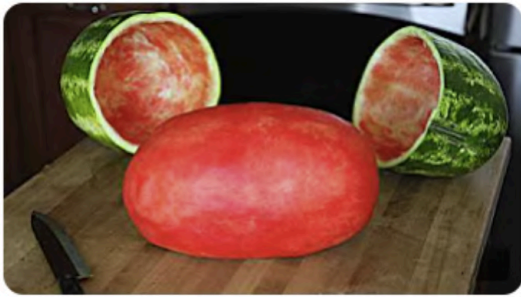
And then some other guy goes, *I got the title for that—entropy, the thing that nobody understands!* And then 17 million people on YouTube are like, *yeah, what is entropy?*



So that's how YouTubers know when to use text—

when you can't show it, *tell* it.

Part of a good text thumbnail has to do with picking the right words. This is still a very good thumbnail without the text:



How to *Peel* a watermelon though would be lame:

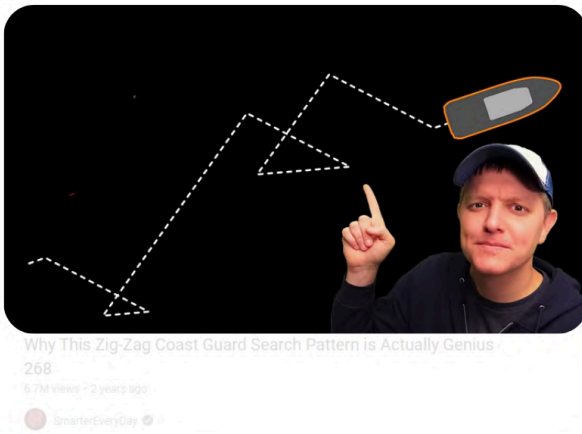


I would have passed on that thumbnail...peeling fruit is not that interesting to me. But he didn't do that, instead he called it:



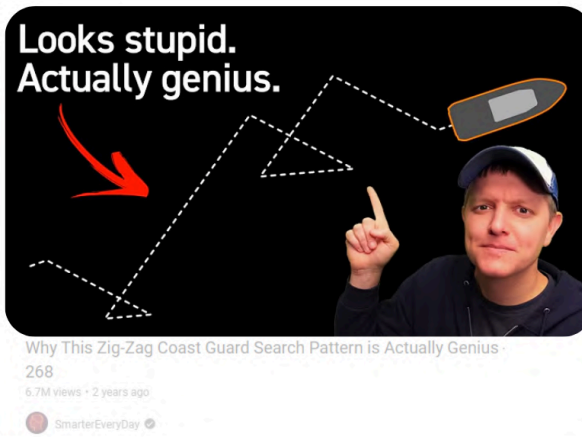
How to skin a watermelon—that's exciting—that's like vegetarian hunting. For a wholesome guy, Mark Rober really knows how to be a bad boy.

Here's a YouTuber pointing to what looks like some sort of dumb zigzag pattern.



I see that and I think, that's pretty stupid.

Guess what his text is:



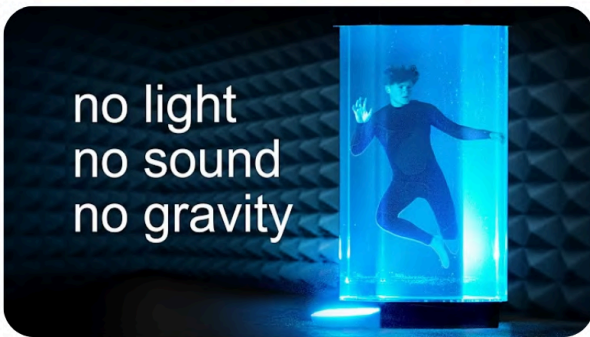
Holy shit this YouTuber read my mind- so that's the **"I know what you're thinking text"**

Imagine a YouTuber has a great idea for a video—surviving a sensory deprivation tank. Now that YouTuber would have two problems.

1. nobody knows what a sensory deprivation tank is.
2. a sensory deprivation tank is where you can't see anything, or feel anything, or hear anything. Now how would you ever be able to visualize that?

Answer: you don't.

Which is why Ryan Trahan is a genius... who just *wrote* it



I Survived Sensory Deprivation

36M views • 2 years ago



Ryan Trahan

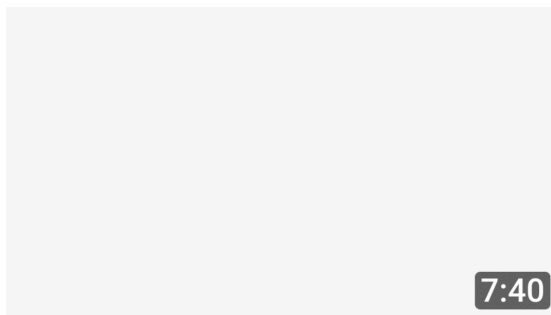
When YouTubers feel really stuck on how to capture something visually, they write it.

8. Minimalism:

So you're scrolling along and it's:

junk
junk
stuff
stuff
clutter
clutter
text
arrows
faces

Whoa



Where Is This Video?



Vsauce · 7.6M views · 11
years ago

wait a second.
Hold up a minute-
where is the thumbnail?!

Welcome to minimalism.

There's not much to say because there's only one thing.

Even if you don't know anything about chairs or care much about chairs, you do know this chair:



This thumbnail stops you in your scroll and makes you think—what did that humble chair do to garner this photo shoot, this close-up, and this type of attention? 3.2 million views on a plastic chair.

For minimalism to work, the YouTuber has to be *beyond confident* that the thumbnail is interesting—it's sliding all your poker chips across the table and going all in on that one thing. And there's a thin line between crazy and brave...but this YouTuber felt that and was brave enough to just put a chair in the thumbnail.

Of course, that's some pretty big talk because you can always change your thumbnail later. But the point is, minimalism looks easy, but it's actually really hard.

Like imagine you're the chief thumbnail designer at this YouTube channel and you walk into corporate headquarters one day and say, I'd like to propose a strategic direction for the next thumbnail design. And then you whip off a white curtain and reveal your design on an easel. You say, "I call it chair." And the CEO of this channel goes, "The chair?" And you go, no no...just...chair. But then imagine they go ahead with the chair thumbnail and the video doesn't do well, the CEO of the channel is gonna come back to the thumbnail designer and go, "You just put a chair in there? You're just going to let it ride on a chair? At least say it's the most important chair or something."

So the point is, if you use minimalism in a thumbnail, you better be right because you're betting everything on that one thing.

Ok another example:



How to Make Handmade Candy With Panda Design |
30M views • 8 years ago



Stereokroma

You might not know what these are—I didn't know what these are—but like most of YouTube, there are worlds within *worlds* that you don't know about. And this is a world that people who know, *know* what this is about, and this is a form of minimalism.

For everyone else who doesn't know, these are candies—and they're not just any candies, they're homemade candies. Now once you know they're candies, in the world of homemade candies this is quite a beautiful thumbnail. It's very attractive to the people who enjoy making candy that doesn't look like candy—it looks like something else, that's what they're into, and this looks like something else. I think it's actually supposed to look like bamboo, but correct me if I'm wrong.

Like we said before minimalism works because it stands out from the scroll and all of the focus is on one important thing like this creepy bear here:



Why Are Things Creepy?

24M views • 11 years ago



Vsauce

well there goes my sleep tonight.

Minimalism is a lighthouse focusing all the video's energy into one point and the viewer is the weary sailor who sales to that beacon of light: the video.

9. Maximalism

Now on the opposite side of things we have maximalism. Maximalism is when there's so much in the thumbnail and somehow you're totally interested in everything in the thumbnail but:

- it's not clutter
- it's not mess
- it's not a distraction
- somehow all the information works together in some sort of synergistic “Magic”.

Take one of the masters of maximalism- Johnny Harris. Johnny Harris uses maximalism to show the complicated array of all the players involved in the complicated world that is our world. Look at this Bosnia thumbnail:



The Worst War You Never Learned About, Mapped

9.4M views • 1 year ago

Johnny Harris

- It's Johnny Harris—he's the brand, so that's branding.
- It's got a tank—that means war.
- You got what looks like a mom and a son walking—that means refugees, the personal.
- You got Bosnia, which is the subject.
- You got Bill Clinton, which is the political players, the famejacking
- And to finish it off the background is a Map- that symbolizes Geography.

If he'd only put one of those things in the thumbnail—the Tank, the kids walking—there'd be no reason for me to click. But when he puts it all together we got a geopolitical problem - a War.

His videos are long format, detailed investigative reporting... and so his thumbnail promises what the video delivers.

Drew Gooden uses Maximalism that can be read. It's like a little essay:



The Future of TV is Bleak

3.8M views • 1 year ago

Drew Gooden

The beautiful part is, unlike a word essay, you can read this from left to right or bottom to top or any way you want. Maybe you are into HBO Max, maybe you like talking about terrible shows, maybe you're like, why is there a strike now? But you can just start where you want—crappy shows, striking, streaming services, whatever catches your interest. That's what makes this such a good thumbnail. Choose your own adventure.

This kind of maximalism says chaos:



THE 100,000 CALORIE CHALLENGE!

18M views • 6 years ago

ErikTheElectric



THE ULTIMATE AMERICAN FAST FOOD CHEAT DAY (30,000+ CALOR)

12M views • 6 years ago

ErikTheElectric

I really feel this guy's *energy*.

In case you didn't get the message from the 17,000 labels in the foreground and the look of fear factor rage on his face and his fists of fury, he's also put into the background a pinwheel that, when spun fast enough, communicates the chaos he's trying to convey. And you might be like, that's not for me...that's okay, 18 million people said, well I want to watch that for 58 minutes and 31 seconds.

I would love to see the CPMs on this guy's video, cuz I know every brand wants to advertise with him. So his maximalism is about fun chaos.

But you don't have to be as intense as this guy—you can be much more calm and chill, like James Hoffman here with his coffee creamers:



Too Many Coffee Creamers: A Taste Test
1.2M views • 1 year ago

James Hoffman

James uses the same maximalism format but instead of saying chaos he says *I have a PhD in coffee creamers*- that's the encyclopaedic version of maximalism

Another type of maximalism is the complete guide:



Ultimate Guide to Camera Angles: Every Camera Shot Explained
1.9M views • 4 years ago

StudioBinder

If these guys had just put the word camera angles:



Ultimate Guide to Camera Angles: Every Camera Shot Explained
1.9M views • 4 years ago

StudioBinder

I'd be like 'boring' and scroll on by.

But the fact that they put up a dozen examples of amazing movies makes me feel like they're going to tell me the secrets to the movie universe that I'm going to understand by the end of the video.

It's hard to make maximalism work because all the elements have to be cohesive. It can't be crowded, and there still has to be focus. Which is why, just like minimalism, maximalism is a tough bet, and it's hard to pull off. But when YouTubers do pull it off, it's a great way to show a complicated story—whether it's the complicated geopolitics of Bosnia's relationship to America or what coffee creamer is better. But this thumbnail format should come with a warning that says:

use at your own risk, because you could just end up with a big mess.



Flying To McDonald's On My Paramotor

48M views • 7 years ago



Tucker Gott

If you saw this in person, you'd text your friend and be like, *You're not gonna believe what I just saw—some dude just pulled into the McDonald's drive-thru on some flying apparatus.* And your friend would be like, *whaddya mean a flying apparatus?* And you'd be like, *I dunno, he just dropped down from the sky with some big wheel on his back and now he's eating fries.* And then your friend would stop texting because he'd be on the way over to see that crazy dude. And that's what this thumbnail is all about—you kinda can't believe that this dude actually did it.

What will he order?

What will other people say?

That's a crazy thing to do.

And this thumbnail type is I did something extreme—

10. I did something crazy



Deep Fried Coffee: A Horrifying Discovery

4.3M views • 2 years ago



James Hoffmann

Here we've got Deep Fried Coffee—I can't believe that this is a thing. Why would someone do that? *Does* someone actually do that? Is it any good? When you start thinking about it, there's a lot of good stuff that comes from deep fried. Maybe coffee *would* work? You got me—that is pretty crazy—I'd click on that.



I Counted To 100,000!

30M views • 7 years ago



This thumbnail sucks. Sure, now you look at it and you're like that's Mr. Beast. But 6 years ago no one gave a bleep about young Mr. Beast; even *he* says no one cared about him then. So how is this thumbnail an I did something crazy?

Well, if you don't see the I did something crazy it means you're probably over 23... definitely over 20. Because you know that when you're 13, your 13-year-old eyes used to look at some stuff with hawk eyes—you have "I see everything eyes." You might be dumb...but you see everything. And your eyes are like ray guns—beep beep beep beep—to the 23:48:07. Now all those old people can't see that... we're blind to that now, we just scroll on by. I read a description to decide if I want to click on a video—that's how old I am.

So how is this 'I did something crazy'?

The time stamp.

The time stamp is everything. Every young buck looks at that and says... *is that time stamp 23 hours, 48 minutes, and 7 seconds? Is that even possible? That would be crazy if somebody actually did that. There's no way that video is that long—can you even upload a video that long?* And that's why this thumbnail is I did something crazy.

At one point in time, sending garlic bread to the edge of space was "i did something crazy" until anybody and everybody sent something up to space.



We Sent Garlic Bread to the Edge of Space, Then Ate It

61M views • 6 years ago



Mark rober sent an egg



Egg Drop From Space

121M views • 2 years ago



Mark Rober

Nick sent a slice of pizza



I Sent A Slice Of Pizza To Space, Then Ate It

2.3M views • 2 years ago



Nick DiGiovanni

Dude Perfect sent themselves



Dude Perfect Goes to SPACE

41M views • 2 years ago



Dude Perfect

So that's the thing: when you do something crazy, some other YouTuber will probably catch wind and be like woah that was crazy- maybe I should do that too. And people might watch.

But crazy has a shelf life.

Because when it's not crazy any more, it's just normal. And normal is pretty close to boring.

An I did something crazy makes you feel:

- how is that possible?
- Did they actually do this?!?!?
- And the answer has to be yes: their promise was high but their delivery was even higher.

An *I did Something Crazy* is a very YouTube-y format because on Netflix or Hulu you'd have to tell a room full of executives what your plan was...

You'd walk in and say: *"I'd like to count to 100 000"*

And the studio execs would be all:

"We love it, but let's workshop the concept for six months."

"What if we add a talking animal? Kids love those."

"It's a great idea, but will people binge it?"

But on YouTube, there is no red tape. There's only a red play button. And a global audience for *I did something crazy*.

11. Cautionary Tale

The only thing that humans are attracted to more than winning is losing- humans hate it. And that's why the Cautionary Tale thumbnail is every where on YouTube.



How to Make a Better Peanut Butter and Jelly Sandwich - You're Doing It All Wrong
920K views • 12 years ago

My 9-year-old self could have really used this cautionary tale—do you ever end up with a sandwich like this? Maybe they're going to tell me why I have so many problems. What's great about a cautionary tale thumbnail is

they grab my attention with the problem I have, but I gotta click to find out the solution.



13 Things You Should NEVER Do In Lucid Dreams!
8.8M views • 5 years ago

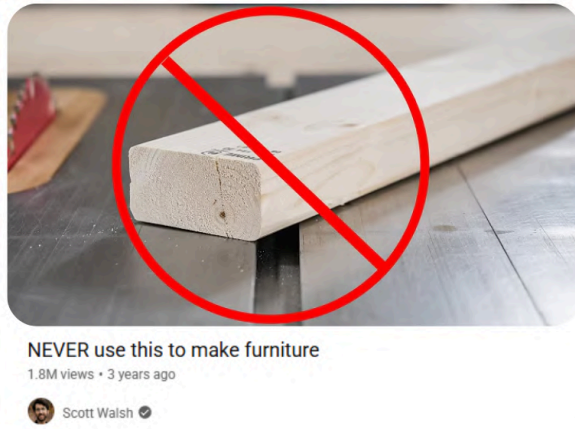
Explore Lucid Dreaming

You might not be familiar with the term lucid dreaming, so let me break this down. There are these people who practice dreaming. You know when you wake up in the morning and you're like, *I just remembered a dream, it was so vivid*? Well, these people do that intentionally. They go to sleep, and when they get in that dream where they're half awake but still dreaming, they don't let it stop. It's a very interesting topic. You will see by the number of millions of views it got. The problem with lucid dreaming is sometimes it can become lucid nightmares, and nobody wants that.

That's where this thumbnail comes in: sharks and surfing. I can see that dreaming about this would be very bad. I think pretty much everybody, besides a few crazy people on YouTube, does not like swimming with great white sharks. So they might wonder, how can I prevent that? That's what a cautionary tale thumbnail is all about—

they show me pain, I say I'm scared of that pain, and then I click to figure out how to avoid that pain.

In the case of this thumbnail, **8.5 million people** were interested in preventing shark dreams from haunting their future selves.



Let's say I was going to make furniture, I was going to use that lumber—that cheap stuff at Home Depot. Damn... got to watch it to find out why. But the 1.8 million people who watched this is actually made up of 2 types of people—

1. the people making furniture for the first time,
2. the people who already know that you're not supposed to use this lumber. Why would they click if they already know? **Smugness**. They can listen to this video with a smug smile on their face and be like, *I already knew that*.

So a cautionary tale **can appeal to beginners and experts**.

All of these thumbnails could have just told you the right way to do things—the right wood to buy, the right way to make a PB and J, the right way to dream—but that wouldn't have been nearly as interesting. If they give away the answer in the thumbnail, why would you click on the video? You wouldn't. And that's why the cautionary tale thumbnail is everywhere.

You're doing chinups wrong- cautionary tale



I wasted 7.5 years of life learning guitar the wrong way- cautionary tale



How to Teach Yourself Guitar in 2025 (Save YEARS of WASTED TIME)

3M views • 1 year ago



Don't use tyvek home wrap- cautionary tale



Why I Stopped Using House Wrap

484K views • 5 months ago



Sharks, expensive car bills, wasting wood- that's a lot of different videos but the one thing they all have in common is **pain**.

Humans hate pain- show them how to avoid it and you'll have a subscriber forever.

12. I Want That

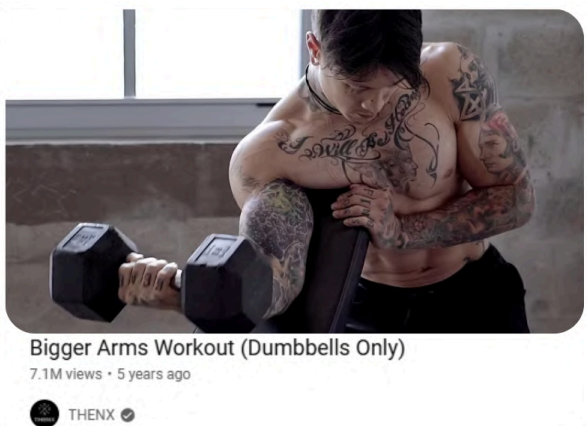
The opposite of the cautionary tale is an *I want that* video. Instead of how do I avoid that pain, it's:

how do I get that thing I love?

Maybe you're into organization—then you'd be like, I want that:



This guy made a beautiful drawer- took him a year to design it, squeezed it into 9 minutes- heads up it's totally worth watching



I'll pass on some of those tattoos but those shoulders? That's me. I want that.



This pocket notebook is (slowly) replacing my phone

4M views · 2 years ago

Austin Schrock

This video is going to be about note-taking, the *frugal* way. This *I want that* is powerful because pretty much anyone in the world can get it. It's 99 cents. That is an **attainable** I want that. And just to make it even more interesting—it's a secret.

The only thing humans love more than solutions to their problems is secret solutions to their problems.

Now the secret to this thumbnail is that the secret isn't where he got that notebook or that it's 99 cents—he's given all that away in the thumbnail. The real secret is he's going to show you how to use this notebook, maybe even to keep off your phone.

I want that is a very wholesome type of thumbnail: people like things, and what they like... they want. It's very simple. Now if you have a recipe behind that thumbnail for how to get that thing, guess what—you have a really great video because **people will click on an I want that, to figure out how to get that.**

13. Cliffhanger

Even if you haven't heard of a cliffhanger before, you've seen it, cuz TV shows use it all the time. Remember the intro to *Breaking Bad*?

It's Walter White with a gas mask on and no clothes except for a pair of tighty whities, driving a ratchet-looking RV through the desert, which makes you want to know what's going to happen next and how did he get here?

Now, if they opened up with some guy in a high school class teaching... BORING. Cliffhangers cut straight to the interesting part, which makes you wonder: how did he get here and what will happen next?

Which is why YouTubers use cliffhangers all the time... like Airrack here.



If You Scream, You Lose: IRL

20M views • 2 years ago



I'm not really sure you can put a video up where rats eat your face but Airrack is implying that by using a cliffhanger to get around the Google algorithm.

It was so successful that he decided to repeat it



Humans VS Robots: 100 Experiments

17M views • 2 years ago



but this time these robots with bad intentions are now pulling him down. So this is like an ex machina cliffhanger.

And then he did it again here- this is like a *rom com* meets *horror movie cliffhanger*.



100 Dates In 24 Hours!

21M views • 2 years ago



I'm a typical human- I've watched people cuddle with leopards and I've seen leopards mess stuff up. In this thumbnail, we are at the moment where this leopard's either going to mess something up or they're going to be best friends- there's no middle ground with leopards. I've learned that from YouTube.



Animals That Asked People for Help & Kindness

38M views • 2 years ago



You don't need a crazy encounter with a leopard or some diabolical robots in order to make a cliffhanger.

This YouTuber did a text version of a cliffhanger:



Dog Doesn't COME When Called? FIX It NOW!

1.1M views • 1 year ago



If you had a dog that never came when you called him, this thumbnail would be very interesting to you. You'd click on that video to find out why and maybe get your dog back.

This Jeep is on a actual cliff which makes it a *literal cliffhanger*.



Jeep wj 4.0

691K views • 2 years ago



TK

What's that parrot going to do to that fluffy cat? Cliffhanger.



Funny Parrots Annoying Cats Compilation

15M views • 9 years ago



mihaifrancu

Oh shit that's a wolf - Cliffhanger.



What to expect if you encounter a wolf

21M views • 5 years ago



Oregon Department of Fish and Wildlife

These are some turkeys- definitely not a cliffhanger



Turkey Sounds

1.1M views • 4 years ago



Oregon Department of Fish and Wildlife

Conclusion

So, there you have it—the 13 thumbnails that make up 91% of YouTube. Now that you’ve seen them, you’ll start spotting them everywhere—they’re all designed to hijack your brain and make you click. And honestly, they do a pretty good job.

Click [here](#) for Thumbnail help.